PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

prd-forge

A domain expert, with no product management training, can reach a PRD that an engineering lead confirms is buildable, and can see for themselves where it is still weak before anyone starts work.

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STATUS	draft
OWNER	Richard Hightower
DOMAIN	product management tooling
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GOLDEN THREAD	J-001
STAKEHOLDERS	Domain experts who must specify software for their own field; Engineering leads who build from the resulting PRD; Delivery leads who run story-mapping workshops

Executive summary

PROBLEM	A domain expert knows exactly what their product must do, but what they can write down is a feature list with no named users, no pass-or-fail criteria and the technology already chosen, so the team that has to build it cannot.
USERS	Domain experts specifying software for their own field, the engineering leads who build from what they write, and the sponsors who approve it.
WHY NOW	Teams now expect to work from a written specification an assistant helped produce, and a specification that reads well but cannot be built from costs more than no specification at all, because it is believed.
BET	A domain expert, with no product management training, can reach a PRD that an engineering lead confirms is buildable, and can see for themselves where it is still weak before anyone starts work.
MEASURE	Share of PRDs that pass an engineering buildability review on the first submission.

Contents

§	SECTION	STATUS	GRADE	BLOCKING
1	Problem and opportunity	draft	—	—
2	Target customer and market	draft	—	—
3	Business objectives and success metrics	draft	—	—
4	Users and personas	draft	—	—
5	User journeys	draft	80/100	1
5	Scenarios	draft	—	—
6	Scope	draft	—	—
7	Functional requirements	draft	84/100	2
8	Non-functional requirements	draft	75/100	2
9	Constraints	draft	—	—
10	Decision rights and trust rules	draft	75/100	7
11	Assumptions, risks and dependencies	draft	—	—
12	Open questions	draft	—	—

§	SECTION	STATUS	GRADE	BLOCKING
13	Release plan	draft	—	—
14	Glossary	draft	—	—
15	Change log and approvals	draft	—	—

About this document

A domain expert knows exactly what their product must do, but what they can write down is a feature list with no named users, no pass-or-fail criteria and the technology already chosen, so the team that has to build it cannot. The users are domain experts specifying software for their own field, the engineering leads who build from what they write, and the sponsors who approve it. Teams now expect to work from a written specification an assistant helped produce, and one that reads well but cannot be built from costs more than no specification at all, because it is believed. The bet is that a domain expert with no product management training can reach a PRD an engineering lead confirms is buildable, and can see for themselves where it is still weak before anyone starts work. We will know it worked from the share of PRDs that pass an engineering buildability review on the first submission.

Contents

SECTION	DOCUMENT
1	Problem and opportunity
2	Target customer and market
3	Business objectives and success metrics
4	Users and personas
5	User journeys
5	Scenarios
6	Scope
7	Functional requirements
8	Non-functional requirements
9	Constraints
10	Decision rights and trust rules
11	Assumptions, risks and dependencies
12	Open questions
13	Release plan
14	Glossary

SECTION	DOCUMENT
15	Change log and approvals

A note on this PRD

This is prd-forge's PRD, written with prd-forge's own conventions. Writing it surfaced one real tension, recorded as C-001: the product is delivered inside an assistant the expert already uses, and naming that delivery mechanism in a requirement would fail test 5. The platform is therefore a constraint, and the requirements in section 7 describe only what a person does and sees.

SECTION 1

Problem and opportunity

DRAFT

ID	PROBLEM	WHO
P-001	What the expert writes is a feature list with no user and no testable outcome	Domain expert
P-002	The steps between requirements are never written, so paths have gaps	Engineering lead
P-003	Buildability is invisible until the team starts building	Sponsor or approver
P-004	No source of PRD craft at the moment the expert needs it	Domain expert

The four compound. P-004 means the expert does not know what good looks like; P-001 is what they produce as a result; P-002 is the specific gap that costs the most; and P-003 is why none of it is caught before it is expensive.

Evidence note. The evidence above describes a pattern, not a measurement. No figure here is sourced, and three of the objectives in section 3 have no baseline for the same reason — see Q-001, Q-002 and Q-003. Measure your own intake before relying on any of it.

P-001

STATEMENT

A domain expert can describe what their product must do out loud, but what they write down is a feature list: no named user, no outcome anyone could check, and a technology already chosen for reasons they cannot defend.

WHO

Domain expert specifying software for their own field

EVIDENCE

- Specifications arriving at delivery teams are commonly feature lists; teams report re-deriving the user and the acceptance criteria themselves before they can estimate. Quantify this from your own intake before you rely on it.
- Experts asked to write requirements reach for the words of the software they have used, because that is the only requirements language they have been exposed to.

WHY NOW

Specifications are now commonly drafted with an assistant, which makes them fluent. Fluent and unbuildable is a worse failure than rough and unbuildable, because nobody queries it.

COST OF INACTION

The gap is closed by an engineer guessing, during build, at what the expert meant, and the guess is discovered at review or in production.

P-002

STATEMENT

Requirements are written one at a time, so the steps between them are never written at all, and nobody notices until the team tries to assemble a working path through the product.

WHO

Engineering lead building from the specification

EVIDENCE

- A specification with no user journey gives a story-mapping workshop no backbone, so features and epics cannot be derived from it at all.
- Gaps surface as mid-iteration questions about what happens between two requirements that both looked complete.

WHY NOW

Teams are committing to outcomes per release, which needs a complete path through the product, not a complete list of features.

COST OF INACTION

The release line is drawn across a feature list rather than a journey, so a release ships features and no user can complete anything with them.

P-003

STATEMENT

Nobody can tell a buildable specification from a readable one until the team has already started building from it.

WHO

Sponsor or approver signing the specification off

EVIDENCE

- Approval is given on readability and completeness of headings, because those are the only properties an approver can assess unaided.
- The first real assessment of buildability happens when an engineer estimates, which is after approval and after the plan was made.

WHY NOW

Where the document was drafted with an assistant, readability is no longer any evidence at all of buildability.

COST OF INACTION

Plans and commitments are made on an approved document whose defects are found by the people asked to deliver against them.

P-004

STATEMENT

An expert has nowhere to learn what a section of a PRD is for at the moment they are being asked to fill it in.

WHO

Domain expert specifying software for their own field

EVIDENCE

- Templates name the sections and not their purpose, so a heading like "non-functional requirements" is filled with adjectives.
- The craft exists in books and in experienced product managers, neither of which is available at the moment the expert is typing.

WHY NOW

Organisations are asking domain experts to specify directly, without routing the work through a product manager first.

COST OF INACTION

Each expert reinvents the form badly, and the organisation's specifications cannot be compared to one another or improved as a body of work.

SECTION 2

Target customer and market

DRAFT

ID	SEGMENT	BUYER	USER
S-001	Consultancies specifying from client domain knowledge	Principal or practice lead	The consultant
S-002	Regulated-industry organisations where practitioners specify	Head of product or delivery	The practitioner
S-003	Product teams entering an unfamiliar domain	Head of product	Product manager

S-003 is listed last deliberately. That segment already has the product skill and wants domain knowledge, which this product does not supply — it supplies product management to someone who already has the domain. Treat S-003 as a weak fit until Q-004 says otherwise.

Why we win

The expert can see, before anyone starts building, which parts of their own specification a development team will not be able to build from, and what to answer to fix it. No competitor above tells them that.

Honest weakness. Against a contracted product manager we have no quality edge, only availability and cost. A sceptical buyer is right to test that.

Segments

S-001 · Consultancies and advisory firms turning client domain knowledge into specifications

BUYER	Principal or practice lead
USER	The consultant with the domain knowledge
SIZE	`<count>` firms, per `<a named register, with its year>` — not yet measured; see Q-004.
WILLINGNESS TO PAY	Already pays for the consultant's time; the comparison is billable hours saved, not a software budget.

S-002 · Regulated-industry organisations where practitioners specify their own internal software

BUYER	Head of product, delivery lead, or head of transformation
USER	The practitioner, plus the delivery lead who reviews what they write
SIZE	Not yet measured; see Q-004.
WILLINGNESS TO PAY	Compared against contracting a product manager for the engagement.

S-003 · Product teams entering a domain they do not know

BUYER	Head of product
USER	Product manager, interviewing practitioners
SIZE	Not yet measured; see Q-004.
WILLINGNESS TO PAY	Lowest of the three: they already employ the product skill and want the domain, which this does not supply.

Competitors

A blank PRD template in the team's document tool

OFFER	The section headings, immediately, free, in a tool everyone already has.
OUR EDGE	A heading asks a question the expert cannot answer; this teaches the section first and then asks the questions that produce an answer.

A general-purpose assistant conversation with no structure

OFFER	Fluent prose on any section, instantly, with no setup at all.
OUR EDGE	Fluency is the failure mode in P-003. The difference here is the grading: the expert is told where the document is weak, against a stated rubric, by a reviewer that did not write it.

Contracting a product manager for the engagement

OFFER	Genuine product judgement, and someone accountable for the outcome.
OUR EDGE	None on quality. The edge is availability and cost at the moment the expert is typing, and that the expert keeps the understanding afterwards rather than renting it.

The status quo - a smart practitioner, a document, and a willing engineer

OFFER	No tool, no cost, no adoption, and it does sometimes work.
OUR EDGE	It works when the engineer is willing to re-derive the specification and is in the room. It fails on handover, on scale, and on anything the engineer cannot ask about.

SECTION 3

Business objectives and success metrics

DRAFT

ID	OBJECTIVE	METRIC	BASELINE	TARGET
O-001	Buildable without re-derivation	Pass rate on first buildability review	unknown (Q-001)	80%
O-002	Days, not weeks, to an approved spec	Median working days, first question to approval	unknown (Q-002)	under 5
O-003	Requirements testable as written	Share of `must` requirements an outside engineer can test	unknown (Q-003)	95%

Why there are no baselines

All three baselines are unknown, and each has a matching open question with a decider and a date. That is deliberate and it is the honest state: this product has not run against a real engagement yet. The targets above are therefore intentions, not commitments, and section 15 should record the moment each baseline arrives and each target is either confirmed or changed.

A reviewer should push on this. An objective with an invented baseline is worse than one with an admitted gap, because the invented one gets planned against.

What would move these without this product

Worth asking, and recorded here because the answer is not nothing: a single experienced product manager embedded with the expert would move all three. The bet is on availability and cost, not on beating that person — see section 2.

O-001

OBJECTIVE	A specification handed to a development team can be built from without the team re-deriving it first.
METRIC	Share of PRDs that pass an engineering buildability review on first submission, where the review is the eleven derivability checks.
BASELINE	unknown - not measured; see Q-001. Do not set a target against this until Q-001 is answered.
TARGET	80% of PRDs pass on first submission.
BY	2027-09-30
OWNER	Richard Hightower

O-002

OBJECTIVE	A domain expert reaches an approved specification in days rather than the weeks a product manager's discovery cycle takes.
METRIC	Median elapsed working days from the first interview question to an approval recorded in section 15.
BASELINE	unknown - not measured; see Q-002.
TARGET	Under 5 working days for a single-journey product.
BY	2027-09-30
OWNER	Richard Hightower

O-003

OBJECTIVE	Requirements are testable as written, so a team can close them without asking the author what they meant.
METRIC	Share of functional requirements whose acceptance criteria an engineer who was not in the interview judges sufficient to write a test.
BASELINE	unknown - not measured; see Q-003.
TARGET	95% of `must` requirements.
BY	2027-09-30
OWNER	Richard Hightower

SECTION 4

Users and personas

DRAFT

ID	ROLE	FREQUENCY	MAY APPROVE
PER-001	Domain expert specifying their own field	Weeks per product, then rarely	Scope; not the PRD itself
PER-002	Engineering lead building from it	A handful of intensive reads	May reject as not buildable
PER-003	Sponsor or approver	Once per version	The PRD for a release
PER-004	Delivery lead running story mapping	Once per release	Backlog shape and order

PER-001 is the primary persona

Everything is designed around someone with deep domain knowledge, no product training, and a burst of intense use followed by months away. Two consequences run through the rest of this PRD: nothing may assume prior knowledge of product vocabulary, and the work must survive being put down for a week and picked back up — see FR-002 and NFR-004.

Who is deliberately not a persona

The assistant that delivers the teaching, the interview and the grading is not a user of this product. It is how the product reaches PER-001. Listing it here would put the delivery mechanism into the PRD, which section 9 keeps as a constraint instead. The same goes for the grading reviewers: a reviewer that grades a section is a mechanism, and what matters to this PRD is that PER-001 sees a grade they did not produce themselves.

PER-001 · Domain expert specifying software for their own field

GOALS

- Get what is in my head into a form the development team can build from
- Stop being asked the same question by four different engineers
- Not be the reason the project is late

PAINS

- I know what it must do, and I cannot write it the way they need it
- I am told my requirements are not testable and I do not know what that means
- I reach for the names of software I have used, because that is the only requirements language I have

FREQUENCY

Intensively for one to three weeks per product, then almost never until the next one.

AUTHORITY

Decides what the product must do and what is out of scope; may not approve the PRD for a release on their own where a sponsor exists.

PROFICIENCY

Deep in their domain, often decades. No product management training. Assume no familiarity with MoSCoW, Given/When/Then, or the word "persona".

PER-002 · Engineering lead who must build from the PRD

GOALS	• Estimate without first interviewing the author • Know which decisions are mine and which have been made for me • Find out now, not in iteration three, what the document does not say
PAINS	• Specifications that name a technology and so pre-empt my decision badly • Requirements I cannot write a test for • Gaps between two requirements that both looked complete
FREQUENCY	Reads a given PRD a handful of times, intensively, at estimation and at each release planning.
AUTHORITY	Decides how it is built; may reject a PRD as not buildable.
PROFICIENCY	Expert in delivery, usually knows nothing about the expert's domain.

PER-003 · Sponsor or approver

GOALS	• Be confident enough to commit budget and a date • Know what is still undecided, and who is deciding it
PAINS	• I can only judge whether it reads well • I find out it was not buildable after I have committed to the plan
FREQUENCY	Once per version, plus conditions.
AUTHORITY	Approves the PRD for a release; may approve with conditions; may reject.
PROFICIENCY	Senior in the business, not in product or engineering.

PER-004 · Delivery lead running the story-mapping workshop

GOALS	• Walk into the workshop with a backbone already agreed • Trace every story back to something the expert actually said
PAINS	• No journey means no backbone, so the workshop invents one in the room • Stories that trace to nothing, so nobody can say why they exist
FREQUENCY	Once per release, plus refinement.
AUTHORITY	Decides the backlog's shape and order; does not decide scope.
PROFICIENCY	Expert in agile delivery; depends entirely on the PRD for the domain.

SECTION 5

User journeys

DRAFT 80/100 1 BLOCKING

J-001 - A domain expert reaches an approved, buildable PRD (golden thread)

Persona PER-001. Trigger: they have been asked to specify a product and have nothing written. Stages ST-001 to ST-006.

STAGE	ACTOR	DECISION
ST-001 States the idea and the domain	Domain expert	What this is, and the domain's own words
ST-002 Taught a section, then interviewed	Domain expert	Have the questions reached the end of what they know
ST-003 Reads the draft and its grade	Domain expert	Accept, correct, or dispute the grade
ST-004 Answers the one question that matters most	Domain expert	Is this section done enough to leave
ST-005 Sees whether a team could build it	Domain expert	Is it ready for someone who will commit
ST-006 Approver approves for a release	Sponsor or approver	Approve, approve with conditions, or reject

ST-002 to ST-004 are a loop, run once per section. That is the whole product: the expert is taught, asked, shown a draft, shown a grade, and asked one more thing.

End state: approved at a named version, every section graded with nothing blocking, every open question owned and dated, and an engineering lead has said it can be built from.

J-002 - A delivery lead derives a backlog (not the golden thread)

Persona PER-004, stages ST-007 and ST-008. Release 1 does not have to complete this journey — see section 6 — but the PRD must carry what it needs, which is what ST-007 checks.

What these journeys deliberately do not say

No stage says where the teaching text comes from, how a grade is computed, or what reviews the set in ST-005. Those are mechanisms. Every stage above names a person, what they do and see, and what they decide.

> **J-001 · An approved PRD that an engineering lead confirms can be built from.**
>
> PERSONA PER-001
>
> TRIGGER The expert has been asked to specify a product, or has an idea they want built, and has nothing written down.
>
> GOLDEN THREAD yes

STAGES

Expert states the idea and their domain

ID	ST-001
ACTOR	Domain expert
STEPS	• Says what they want built, in their own words, however roughly • Is asked what the business domain is and what the unit of work is called - an engagement, a load, a claim, a case • Names three words their team uses that an outsider would misread • Sees that a set of documents now exists, every section listed and marked as not yet started
INPUTS	• The idea, the domain, and the vocabulary
OUTPUTS	• A document set with every section visible and honestly marked empty
DECISION	What this product is, and what the domain's own words are

Expert is taught a section, then interviewed on it

ID	ST-002
ACTOR	Domain expert
STEPS	• Reads what the section is, why it matters, and what belongs in it, in under ten lines, with an example from their own domain • Is asked one or two questions at a time, in their own vocabulary • Is asked follow-ups where an answer was thin • Says when they have nothing more to add
INPUTS	• Their knowledge of the domain, in answer to each question
OUTPUTS	• Enough material for the section to be drafted
DECISION	Whether the questions have reached the end of what they know

Expert reads the draft and its grade

ID	ST-003
ACTOR	Domain expert
STEPS	• Reads the drafted section as prose, not as a form • Sees a score, how many blocking defects there are, and what each one is • Sees which part of the section is weakest, and why • Decides whether the grade is fair
INPUTS	• Nothing; this is where they read
OUTPUTS	• A judgement on whether the draft says what they meant
DECISION	Accept the draft, correct it, or dispute the grade

Expert answers the one question that improves it most

ID	ST-004
ACTOR	Domain expert
STEPS	• Reads a single question, not a list of twelve • Answers it, or says why the premise is wrong • Sees the section re-graded against the same rubric • Moves to the next section, or goes back to an earlier one when this section showed it was incomplete
INPUTS	• One answer
OUTPUTS	• A section at a grade the expert accepts, and a set that is one section further on
DECISION	Whether this section is done enough to leave
HANDOFF	Back into ST-002 for the next section, until every section has been through this loop.

Expert sees whether a development team could build it

ID	ST-005
ACTOR	Domain expert
STEPS	• Asks for the whole set to be reviewed as a builder would read it • Sees what a builder could not build, and what they would have to guess • Sees which release-line stages have no requirement behind them • Fixes the holes, or records them as open questions with a decider
OUTPUTS	• A list of what is not buildable, and a set with those holes closed
DECISION	Is this ready to be read by someone who will commit to it
HANDOFF	Sponsor or approver

Approver approves the PRD for a release

ID	ST-006
ACTOR	Sponsor or approver
STEPS	• Reads the summary, the scope, and what is still open • Sees each section's grade and whether anything is still blocking • Approves, approves with conditions naming what the condition is, or rejects • Sees the approval recorded against this version
INPUTS	• Their decision and any conditions
OUTPUTS	• An approved PRD at a named version, with the approval recorded
DECISION	Approve, approve with conditions, or reject
HANDOFF	Delivery lead, for the story-mapping workshop

PAIN POINTS

- I do not know what the section is for, so I fill the heading with adjectives
- Nobody tells me my requirements are untestable until a team tries to build them
- I reach for the names of software I have used
- I put this down for a week and cannot remember where I was
- I cannot tell whether what I have written is good

NEEDS

- Teach me the section before you ask me about it, in my own domain
- Tell me where it is weak, against a stated standard, and ask me one thing
- Convert my technology talk into the need underneath it, without arguing
- Let me stop and resume without starting over
- Show me, before anyone builds, what a builder cannot build

END STATE

The set is approved at a named version, every section has a grade with no blocking defects, every open question has a decider and a date, and an engineering lead has said it can be built from.

J-002 · A backlog whose every story traces to a requirement the expert actually stated.

PERSONA

PER-004

TRIGGER

The PRD has been approved for a release.

STAGES

Delivery lead checks the PRD can carry a backlog

ID

ST-007

ACTOR

Delivery lead

STEPS

- Sees whether a journey exists and which one is the golden thread
- Sees which release-line stages have requirements behind them
- Sees what would block deriving a backlog, before the workshop

OUTPUTS

- A go or no-go on holding the story-mapping workshop

DECISION

Is there a backbone to map against

Delivery lead derives features, epics and stories

ID

ST-008

ACTOR

Delivery lead

STEPS

- Sees one feature per journey stage, with the requirement ids it carries
- Sees epics scoped by the release line
- Sees a story per requirement, in the persona's own words, with the requirement's criteria as its acceptance criteria
- Sees spikes for the open questions that block the release line

OUTPUTS

- A backlog whose every level names what it came from

DECISION

Which epics come first, and why

HANDOFF

The engineering team, for iteration planning

PAIN POINTS	• The workshop invents a backbone in the room because the PRD has none • Stories trace to nothing, so nobody can say why they exist • Non-functional requirements and constraints are forgotten until late
NEEDS	• A journey to map against, agreed before the workshop • Every story carrying the requirement id it came from • Constraints arriving as definition-of-done items, not as surprises
END STATE	Features, epics, stories and spikes exist for release 1, each naming the PRD requirement ids behind it, and no task or estimate has been invented yet.

SECTION 5

Scenarios

DRAFT

ID	STAGE	VARIANT	WHAT IT COVERS
SC-001	ST-002	happy	A section taught, interviewed, drafted, graded, improved
SC-002	ST-004	alternate	Resuming after eight days away
SC-003	ST-002	exception	The expert states a technology
SC-004	ST-003	exception	The expert refutes a grading finding
SC-005	ST-005	exception	Buildability review finds holes
SC-006	ST-002	exception	The expert has no baseline for a metric

SC-001 is the end-to-end acceptance test for release 1.

The four exceptions are the ones that decide whether this product is trustworthy. SC-003 and SC-006 are where a specification quietly acquires a technology choice or an invented fact. SC-004 is where the grading either earns the expert's trust or loses it: a reviewer that cannot be refuted is a reviewer nobody believes. SC-005 is the moment the product is supposed to pay for itself.

SC-001

CONTEXT
A freight operations manager is on section 5 of their first PRD. Sections 1 and 4 are drafted and graded. They have 40 minutes before a meeting.

JOURNEY
J-001

STAGE
ST-002

PERSONA
PER-001

VARIANT
happy

TRIGGER
They say they are ready to do the journeys section.

COURSE
- They read eight lines on what a user journey is, why requirements written one at a time miss the steps between them, and what a stage must name
- They are asked to pick one person and one thing that person is trying to finish
- They say "a dispatcher getting a late load recovered"
- They are asked for the big steps, names only, and give five
- They are asked, per stage, who acts, what they see and what they decide
- They see a drafted journey with five stages, and a grade of 78 with no blocking defects
- They are asked one question - what the dispatcher decides at stage three - and answer it
- They see the journey re-graded at 88

EXPECTED OUTCOME
The journeys section is at status draft with a score of 88 and no blocking defects, one journey is marked as the golden thread, and every stage names an actor and a decision.

SC-002

CONTEXT	The same manager stopped mid-way through section 7 eight days ago. They remember almost nothing about where they were.
JOURNEY	J-001
STAGE	ST-004
PERSONA	PER-001
VARIANT	alternate
TRIGGER	They come back and say they want to carry on.
COURSE	• They see which sections are done, which are drafted, and which have not been started, with each grade • They see that section 7 is at draft with two blocking defects, both named • They are not asked any question they have already answered • They are asked the next question in section 7, in the vocabulary they established in ST-001
EXPECTED OUTCOME	Work resumes at the first section that is not yet at review, no earlier answer is requested again, and the domain vocabulary is unchanged.

SC-003

CONTEXT	A claims manager is answering questions about section 7. They have strong views about how it should be built.
JOURNEY	J-001
STAGE	ST-002
PERSONA	PER-001
VARIANT	exception
TRIGGER	They say "it should push the decision to the adjuster's phone".
COURSE	• They are asked what the adjuster gets from that • They say the adjuster is in the field and cannot wait until they are back at a desk • They see a requirement recorded as the adjuster being able to act on the claim away from their desk, with criteria about what they can do and see • They see that "push to the phone" was kept on a list of candidate architecture decisions, to hand to the engineering lead • No argument is had about whether a notification is the right design
EXPECTED OUTCOME	The requirement names no technology, the user need is recorded, the expert's preference is preserved for the architecture discussion, and the expert does not feel overruled.

SC-004

CONTEXT	The grading reviewer has reported that a requirement names a component. The expert reads the finding and believes it is wrong.
JOURNEY	J-001
STAGE	ST-003
PERSONA	PER-001
VARIANT	exception

TRIGGER
They say the finding is wrong - the word is their domain's own term.

COURSE
- The finding is checked against the document rather than defended
- Where the word is indeed a domain term and not a component, the finding is dropped and the expert is told it was dropped
- Where it is genuinely a component, the reason is stated once, and if the expert still disagrees their decision is recorded with the dissent noted
- The grade reflects what the document says after that decision, not what the reviewer first claimed

EXPECTED OUTCOME
A finding the expert refutes does not survive into the report, the expert is told so plainly, and a disagreement the expert insists on is recorded rather than re-argued at the next grading pass.

SC-005

CONTEXT
The set is complete and every section is at review. The expert asks whether a team could build it. Two release-line stages have no `must` requirement.

JOURNEY
J-001

STAGE
ST-005

PERSONA
PER-002

VARIANT
exception

TRIGGER
They ask for the buildability review.

COURSE
- They see a verdict of buildable with gaps
- They see the two stages that have no requirement behind them, named
- They see three requirements an engineer could not write a test for, each quoted
- They see what the reviewer would ask for first, in order
- They fix two of them and record the third as an open question with a decider and a date

EXPECTED OUTCOME
The expert knows exactly what a builder cannot build before anyone has estimated, and every gap is either closed or owned by a named decider with a date.

SC-006

CONTEXT
The expert is on section 3 and does not know the current value of the metric they have just named.

JOURNEY
J-001

STAGE
ST-002

PERSONA
PER-001

VARIANT
exception

TRIGGER
They are asked for the baseline and say they would have to check.

COURSE
- They are not offered a plausible-looking number
- They are asked who could find out, and by when
- They see an open question recorded with that person and that date, and the objective linked to it
- They see that the target is marked as an intention until the baseline arrives

EXPECTED OUTCOME
No baseline is invented, the objective carries an explicit unknown, and section 12 holds a question with a named decider and a date.

SECTION 6

Scope

DRAFT

Release line

ST-001 through ST-006 for one expert, one PRD, one golden-thread journey.

ID	IN SCOPE	STAGE	REQUIREMENTS
IN-001	Idea, domain, vocabulary, and a visible empty set	ST-001	FR-001, FR-002
IN-002	Teach then interview, in their vocabulary	ST-002	FR-003, FR-004, FR-005
IN-003	No invented facts; convert technology talk	ST-002	FR-006, FR-007
IN-004	Draft as prose, with grade and blocking defects	ST-003	FR-008, FR-009
IN-005	One question, then re-grade	ST-004	FR-010, FR-011
IN-006	Buildability review of the whole set	ST-005	FR-012
IN-007	Approval recorded against a version	ST-006	FR-013, FR-014

Out of scope for R1

ID	OUT OF SCOPE	REVISIT
OUT-001	Deriving the backlog (J-002)	R2; the PRD already carries what it needs
OUT-002	Two experts on one set at once	After three real engagements
OUT-003	Any view beyond the documents and a stepper beside the conversation	When an approver asks

Non-goals

The first is the one that defines the product: **we do not supply domain knowledge.** Someone without the domain is not served by this and should not buy it. The last is the one that protects its users: **a grade is evidence, not a warrant.** A high score on a PRD for the wrong product is still the wrong product.

In scope

IN-001

SUMMARY: State the idea, establish the domain and vocabulary, and create a set with every section visible and honestly marked as not started

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-001

REQUIREMENTS:

- FR-001
- FR-002

IN-002

SUMMARY: Teach a section, then interview on it one or two questions at a time, in the expert's own vocabulary

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-002

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-003
- FR-004
- FR-005

IN-003

SUMMARY: Never record an invented domain fact, and convert a stated technology into the need beneath it

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-002

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-006
- FR-007

IN-004 · Show the draft as prose, with its grade and every blocking defect named

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-003

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-008
- FR-009

IN-005 · Ask one question that most improves the section, and re-grade after it

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-004

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-010
- FR-011

IN-006 · Review the whole set as a builder would, and report what cannot be built

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-005

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-012

IN-007 · Record an approval, with conditions, against a named version

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-006

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-013
- FR-014

Out of scope

OUT-001 · Deriving features, epics and stories from the approved PRD - journey J-002

REVISIT: Release 2. The PRD must already carry what J-002 needs, which FR-012 checks, so nothing is lost by deferring the derivation itself.

OUT-002 · More than one expert working on the same set at the same time

REVISIT: Once a single expert's path is proven on three real engagements.

OUT-003

SUMMARY	Any view of the document set other than reading the documents themselves and stepping through them beside the conversation
REVISIT	When an approver asks for one; PER-003 reads a handful of pages, which the documents already are.

SECTION 7

Functional requirements

DRAFT 84/100 2 BLOCKING

ID	USER	CAPABILITY	PRIORITY	STAGE
FR-001	PER-001	State the idea; establish the vocabulary once	must	ST-001
FR-002	PER-001	See the whole set's state, including after a break	must	ST-001
FR-003	PER-001	Be taught the section before being asked	must	ST-002
FR-004	PER-001	Be asked one or two questions at a time	must	ST-002
FR-005	PER-001	End a section and see what was left behind	must	ST-002
FR-006	PER-001	Unknown facts become open questions, never inventions	must	ST-002
FR-007	PER-001	Technology talk converted; preference preserved	must	ST-002
FR-008	PER-001	Read the draft as prose	must	ST-003
FR-009	PER-001	See score, blocking defects, weakest part	must	ST-003
FR-010	PER-001	Be asked one question, not twelve	must	ST-004
FR-011	PER-001	See the re-grade against the same standard	must	ST-004
FR-012	PER-001	See what a team could not build from it	must	ST-005
FR-013	PER-003	See what is approved and what is open, on one page	must	ST-006
FR-014	PER-003	Approve, with conditions, against a version	must	ST-006

Every release-line stage has at least one `must` requirement. There are no `should` or `could` requirements in R1: the release line is already the smallest path, and anything that could be dropped has been dropped into section 6.

A judgement call worth challenging

FR-002, FR-008 and FR-014 refer to "the set", "the section" and "prose". A reviewer may read those as naming an output format and therefore failing test 5. The judgement taken here is that a written specification is the product's subject, not its delivery technology, so these words name the artifact rather than the mechanism. What is deliberately absent everywhere: the assistant the product runs inside, how grading is performed, who or what reviews the set, and what the documents are stored as. Those are in section 9 as constraints, or nowhere.

FR-001 · State the idea in their own words and establish the domain's vocabulary once

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	Every question they are asked afterwards uses their unit of work and their terms, so they are never translating.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an expert who says the unit of work is a "load", when any later question refers to that unit, then it says "load" and not "item", "record" or "entity". • Given three words the expert says an outsider would misread, when the first section is drafted, then each of those words appears in the glossary with the expert's own meaning. • Given an expert who has not stated a domain, when they ask to begin a section, then they are asked for the domain and the unit of work first.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-001
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-002

CAPABILITY	See every section of the set and what state each one is in, at any point, including after stopping and returning days later
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They always know what is done, what is weak and what has not been started, and they never have to remember where they were.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a set where four sections are drafted and twelve are untouched, when the expert asks where things stand, then they see all sixteen with each one's state, and the untouched ones are shown as not started rather than omitted. • Given an expert returning after eight days, when they say they want to carry on, then work resumes at the first section not yet at review and no question they have already answered is asked again. • Given a section that has been graded, when the expert sees the set's state, then that section shows its score and how many blocking defects it has.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-001
OBJECTIVE	O-002

FR-003

CAPABILITY	Be taught what a section is, why it matters and what belongs in it, before being asked anything about it
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They understand what the section is for well enough to answer from their own knowledge, rather than guessing at what the heading wants.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a section the expert has not done before, when they begin it, then they are first told what it is, why it matters and what belongs in it, in no more than ten lines. • Given a stated domain, when a section is taught, then the example used is in that domain and not in another. • Given an expert who says they already know the section, when they ask to skip the teaching, then the questions begin and the teaching is not forced.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-002
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-004 · Be asked one or two questions at a time, never a questionnaire

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They answer each question properly instead of giving one line to each of twelve.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given any section's interview, when the expert is asked for input, then at most two questions are put to them at once. • Given an answer that is thin or ambiguous, when it is received, then a follow-up is asked about that answer before the next topic is opened. • Given an expert who has answered enough for the section to pass its rubric, when further questions remain unasked on the list, then the interview stops rather than continuing to the end of the list.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-002
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-005 · Say that they have nothing more to add, and have that end the section's interview

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They are never trapped in an interview, and what they chose to leave incomplete is recorded rather than hidden.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an expert who says they are done with a section, when the section does not yet pass its rubric, then it is written anyway at draft, and what is missing is recorded as an open question or named plainly to them. • Given an expert who ends a section early, when they are told what was left behind, then the statement names the specific gap, not just a score.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-002
OBJECTIVE	O-002

FR-006

CAPABILITY	Have a fact they do not know recorded as an open question with a decider and a date, rather than filled in for them
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	Nothing in their PRD is a number or a citation that nobody can stand behind.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an expert who says they would have to check a figure, when the section is drafted, then no figure is written in its place and an open question records who could find out and by when. • Given an objective whose baseline is unknown, when the section is drafted, then the baseline says so explicitly and an open question exists for it. • Given a regulation or standard the expert has not named, when a constraint is drafted, then no regulation number appears that the expert did not supply.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-002
OBJECTIVE	O-001

FR-007

CAPABILITY	State a technology they want and have the need beneath it recorded instead, with their preference preserved for the engineering lead
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	Their requirement names no technology, their reasoning is not lost, and they do not feel overruled.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an expert who names a technology, when they are asked what the user gets from it and answer, then the recorded requirement states that outcome and names no technology, component, vendor or screen. • Given a technology the expert stated, when the set is handed over, then that preference appears on a list of candidate architecture decisions for the engineering lead. • Given an expert who insists the technology belongs in the requirement, when they have been told once why it does not, then their decision is recorded and is not argued again at the next grading pass.

PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-002
OBJECTIVE	O-001

FR-008 · Read the drafted section as prose rather than as a filled-in form

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They can judge whether it says what they meant, without reading a structured record they have no way to assess.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a drafted section, when the expert reviews it, then they are shown its content as prose or a short table, and not as the raw structured record, unless they ask for that. • Given a section whose prose and structured record disagree, when either is read, then the disagreement is reported rather than silently resolved.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-003
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-009 · See a score, every blocking defect by name, and which part of the section is weakest

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They know how good the section is against a stated standard, and what specifically is wrong, rather than being told it looks good.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a graded section, when the expert reads the grade, then they see a score, a count of blocking defects, and each blocking defect stated with where it is. • Given a section with a high score and one blocking defect, when the grade is reported, then the section is not offered as ready, and the defect is named. • Given a graded section, when the expert reads the grade, then the weakest part is named and why it is weak is stated in no more than three lines. • Given a finding the expert refutes by pointing at the document, when it is checked, then a finding not supported by the document is dropped and the expert is told it was dropped.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-003
OBJECTIVE	O-001

FR-010

CAPABILITY	Be asked the single question that would most improve the section, not a list of everything wrong with it
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They can act immediately, and the section improves one answer at a time instead of stalling under a list.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a graded section below its threshold, when the expert is asked to improve it, then exactly one question is put to them. • Given that one question, when it is asked, then it addresses the weakest part that was just named, and not a different part.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-004
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-011 · See the section re-graded against the same standard after answering

USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They can see whether their answer actually improved the section, and by how much.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an answered question, when the section is re-graded, then it is scored against the same rubric as before and both scores are visible. • Given a re-grade, when the score has risen, then the document has changed; a score never rises without a change to the document. • Given a section that has reached its threshold with no blocking defects, when it is re-graded, then the expert is offered the next state and told what that means.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-004
OBJECTIVE	O-003

FR-012

CAPABILITY	See what a development team would not be able to build from the set, before anyone has estimated it
USER	PER-001
OUTCOME	They learn where their own specification fails while it is still cheap to fix, rather than at iteration three.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a complete set, when the expert asks for a buildability review, then they see a verdict and, for each release-line stage, whether a requirement covers it or it is a gap. • Given a requirement an engineer could not write a test for, when the review reports it, then the requirement is named and the document is quoted. • Given an open question that blocks a `must` requirement, when the review runs, then that dependency is reported. • Given a review finding, when it is reported to the expert, then it has been checked against the document and anything not supported by the document has been dropped.
PRIORITY	must

JOURNEY STAGE	ST-005
OBJECTIVE	O-001

FR-013

CAPABILITY	See, on one page, what is being approved, what is still undecided and who owns each undecided thing
USER	PER-003
OUTCOME	They can commit budget and a date knowing what they are committing to and what is still open.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a set offered for approval, when the approver opens it, then they see the summary, the scope, every section's state and grade, and every open question with its decider and date. • Given a set with any blocking defect anywhere, when the approver opens it, then they see that, with the sections it is in.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-006
OBJECTIVE	O-001

FR-014

CAPABILITY	Approve, approve with conditions, or reject, and have that recorded against a named version
USER	PER-003
OUTCOME	What was approved, when, by whom and on what conditions is answerable later without asking anyone.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an approver who approves with conditions, when they state the conditions, then each condition names the open question or requirement it depends on and a date. • Given a recorded approval, when the set is read later, then the version approved, the approver, their role, the date and the decision are all present. • Given an approved set that is then changed, when the change is written, then a new version is recorded and the earlier approval is not represented as covering it.
PRIORITY	must
JOURNEY STAGE	ST-006
OBJECTIVE	O-001

SECTION 8

Non-functional requirements

DRAFT 75/100 2 BLOCKING

ID	CATEGORY	TARGET
NFR-001	performance	Next question under 20s at p95
NFR-002	performance	Section grade under 90s at p95
NFR-003	scale	120 requirements, 10 journeys x 10 stages, 200 terms
NFR-004	durability	100% of a set readable with no part of the product running
NFR-005	usability	90% of sections completed without asking what a term means
NFR-006	accessibility	Zero WCAG 2.2 AA violations on the golden-thread path
NFR-007	observability	100% of grades reconstructable after the session
NFR-008	privacy	Zero destinations beyond the session the expert already uses
NFR-009	supportability	100% of older sets readable within a major version

Where these came from

NFR-001 and NFR-002 come from PER-001's frequency: a burst of intense use. A 20-second wait is tolerable once; across 60 questions it is 20 minutes of dead time and the expert stops.

NFR-004 is the one that matters most and is cheapest to get wrong. PER-001 works in bursts weeks apart. If the set is only readable through this product, then a version change, a tool change or an expired session destroys weeks of an expert's thinking. The target is deliberately absolute.

NFR-005 is the only requirement here that needs people rather than instruments to measure, and it is the one most likely to be skipped. It is the direct test of whether P-004 was solved.

NFR-006 covers the approver too, not only the expert: PER-003 reads this once and must not need a mouse to do it.

NFR-001

STATEMENT	An expert answering a question does not lose their train of thought waiting for the next one.
CATEGORY	performance
METRIC	95th percentile elapsed time from the expert submitting an answer to the next question or the drafted section appearing.
TARGET	under 20 seconds at p95, and under 60 seconds at p99
MEASUREMENT	Timed across a scripted run of all sixteen sections, repeated per release, in the same conditions a user has.
PRIORITY	must
APPLIES TO	• FR-004 • FR-010

NFR-002 · A grading pass does not make the expert wait so long that they stop asking for one.

CATEGORY	performance
METRIC	95th percentile elapsed time for a section's grade to be reported
TARGET	under 90 seconds at p95 for a single section
MEASUREMENT	Timed per release across all sixteen sections.
PRIORITY	must
APPLIES TO	• FR-009 • FR-011

NFR-003 · A set stays workable at the size real products reach.

CATEGORY	scale
METRIC	Number of requirements, journey stages and glossary terms in one set at which every function in section 7 still meets its targets.
TARGET	120 functional requirements, 10 journeys of 10 stages, and 200 glossary terms
MEASUREMENT	A generated set at those sizes, run through every function in section 7, per release.
PRIORITY	must

NFR-004 · Work survives the expert stopping, and survives the tool they were using going away.

CATEGORY	durability
METRIC	Share of a set's content recoverable after the authoring session ends, with no part of the product running.
TARGET	100%, readable without this product
MEASUREMENT	End a session mid-section, then read the whole set with nothing but a text editor, once per release.
PRIORITY	must
APPLIES TO	• FR-002

NFR-005

STATEMENT	An expert with no product management training can complete a section without asking anyone what a word means.
CATEGORY	usability
METRIC	Share of sections a first-time expert completes without asking for the meaning of a product management term.
TARGET	90% of sections, measured over 10 first-time experts
MEASUREMENT	Observed sessions with 10 first-time experts before release, questions to the observer counted and categorised.
PRIORITY	must

NFR-006

STATEMENT	Everything the expert and the approver read is usable with a screen reader and without a mouse.
CATEGORY	accessibility
METRIC	Conformance of the output documents and the stepping view to WCAG 2.2 AA on the golden-thread journey.
TARGET	zero level-A or level-AA violations on the golden-thread path
MEASUREMENT	One manual screen-reader pass of the golden-thread journey per release, plus an automated check of the stepping view in the release pipeline.
PRIORITY	must

NFR-007 · An expert can tell why a section received the score it did, after the fact.

CATEGORY	observability
METRIC	Share of grades for which the score per rubric dimension and the quotation behind each can be recovered after the session.
TARGET	100% for any section at review or better
MEASUREMENT	Re-read a graded set a week later and reconstruct every score, once per release.
PRIORITY	should
APPLIES TO	• FR-009

NFR-008

STATEMENT	What the expert says about their domain stays within whatever boundary their organisation already works in; this product adds no new place for it to go.
CATEGORY	privacy
METRIC	Number of destinations the product sends set content to beyond the assistant session the expert is already using.
TARGET	zero
MEASUREMENT	Review of every outbound destination per release, recorded against C-003.
PRIORITY	must

NFR-009 · A set written by an earlier version is still readable and still gradable by a later one.

CATEGORY	supportability
METRIC	Share of sets written by version N that version N+1 reads and grades without the expert rewriting anything.
TARGET	100% within a major version
MEASUREMENT	Keep one set per released version and run the current version against all of them, per release.
PRIORITY	should

SECTION 9

Constraints

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ID	CATEGORY	CONSTRAINT	AUTHORITY
C-001	firm	Runs inside an assistant session the expert already uses	Product decision, v0.1.0
C-002	firm	Output is plain documents; not the system of record	Product decision, v0.1.0
C-003	policy	Domain content goes nowhere beyond that session	The customer's own information policy
C-004	legal	No unverified citation stated as fact	Professional liability

C-001 is the honest one

Three of these four are our own decisions, not rules imposed from outside, and listing a product decision as a constraint is normally wrong. They are here because C-001 in particular is the tension this PRD ran into: the product is delivered inside an assistant, naming that in a requirement fails test 5, and pretending the dependency does not exist would be worse. Recording it as a constraint keeps section 7 clean and keeps the dependency visible.

A reviewer is entitled to call C-001 and C-002 architecture rather than constraints. The counter-argument is that both are commitments to the customer about what they will have to adopt and what they will own afterwards, which is scope, not design. Decide for yourself; the argument is recorded either way.

C-004 is the one with teeth

C-004 is the only constraint here imposed from outside, and it is the reason FR-006 exists. A fluent PRD with an invented clause number is the failure this product must not have, because the expert signs it, circulates it, and carries the consequence personally.

C-001

STATEMENT
The product reaches the expert inside an assistant session they are already working in. There is no separate application for them to open, install or log into.

CATEGORY
firm

AUTHORITY
Product decision, Richard Hightower, recorded at version 0.1.0. Not externally imposed; recorded here because every requirement in section 7 depends on it and naming it in a requirement would fail test 5.

APPLIES TO
- all

VERIFICATION
No requirement in section 7 names the delivery mechanism, checked at each grading pass.

C-002

STATEMENT
The output is plain text documents the organisation stores wherever it already stores documents. The product is not the system of record for a PRD.

CATEGORY
firm

AUTHORITY
Product decision, Richard Hightower, recorded at version 0.1.0.

APPLIES TO
- all

VERIFICATION
NFR-004's test - read a complete set with nothing but a text editor.

C-003

STATEMENT
Content an expert enters about their domain is not sent anywhere beyond the assistant session they are already using, and is not retained by this product outside the documents themselves.

CATEGORY
policy

AUTHORITY
The expert's own organisation's information policy, whichever it is; this constraint holds for every customer and is not configurable.

APPLIES TO
- all

VERIFICATION
NFR-008's measurement - zero additional destinations.

C-004

STATEMENT
No regulation, standard, clause or statistic is stated as fact unless the expert supplied it or it has been verified against the source; otherwise it is marked unverified or becomes an open question.

CATEGORY
legal

AUTHORITY
Professional liability. An expert circulating a PRD that cites a regulation incorrectly is exposed personally and professionally, whatever this product's terms say.

APPLIES TO
- FR-006
- FR-009
- FR-012

VERIFICATION
Every citation in a set checked against its source before any section reaches final, and anything unverifiable reported as unverified.

SECTION 10

Decision rights and trust rules

DRAFT 75/100 7 BLOCKING

ID	DECISION	APPROVER	AGENT MAY DECIDE	NEVER DELEGATED
TR-001	Approve a PRD for a release	PER-003	no	yes
TR-002	Set a section to final	PER-001	no	yes
TR-003	Score a section against its rubric	PER-001	**yes**	no
TR-004	Decide scope	PER-001	no	yes
TR-005	State a domain fact as true	PER-001	no	yes
TR-006	Judge buildability	PER-002	**yes**	no

The shape of the trust boundary

Only two of six are delegable, and both are **assessments**, not decisions: TR-003 scores a document and TR-006 judges whether it can be built from. Both produce evidence for a person. Neither changes the document, and neither can set a state.

Everything that commits anyone to anything — approving, finalising, choosing scope, asserting a fact — is never delegated. TR-005 is the strictest: a fact nobody can stand behind is not written at all, by anyone.

The two delegable assessments both carry the same two obligations: **quote the document for every claim**, and **drop any finding the document does not support**. An assessment that cannot be refuted by pointing at the text is not evidence, it is an assertion, and the expert will correctly stop believing it — see R-002 in section 11.

TR-001 · Approve a PRD for a release

APPROVER	PER-003
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	no
NEVER DELEGATED	yes
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	The summary, the scope, every section's state and grade, every blocking defect, and every open question with its decider and date.
ESCALATION	No substitute approver. Approval waits. A set is never treated as approved because its score is high.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a set with any blocking defect, when approval is sought, then the approver is shown the defects and the set is not presented as ready. • Given a set with no recorded approval, when anyone reads its state, then it reads as not approved, whatever its scores are.

TR-002 · Set a section's state to final

APPROVER	PER-001
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	no
NEVER DELEGATED	yes
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	The section's grade, its blocking defect count, and the result of validating it.
ESCALATION	The expert may override the gate; the override and the score at the time are recorded in the change log.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a section with one or more blocking defects, when final is requested, then it is not set without an explicit override from the expert. • Given an override, when it is applied, then the change log records that it was an override and the score at the time.

TR-003 · Score a section against its rubric

APPROVER	PER-001
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	yes
NEVER DELEGATED	no
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	The rubric's dimensions and a quotation from the document for every score below full marks.
ESCALATION	The expert may refute any finding by pointing at the document; a finding the document does not support is dropped.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a score below full marks on a dimension, when it is reported, then a quotation from the document is given for it. • Given a finding the expert refutes and the document does not support, when it is checked, then it is dropped and the expert is told it was dropped.

TR-004 · Decide what the product is for and what is out of scope

APPROVER	PER-001
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	no
NEVER DELEGATED	yes
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	What the consequence of the choice is, including any release-line stage it would leave uncovered.
ESCALATION	None. The expert decides. Where the choice weakens the PRD, the objection is stated once and the decision is recorded with the dissent noted.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given an expert decision that leaves a release-line stage uncovered, when it is recorded, then the consequence is stated to the expert once and the decision stands. • Given a decision the expert reaffirmed after an objection, when later grading passes run, then the objection is not raised again as a new finding.

TR-005 · State a domain fact, figure, regulation or citation as true

APPROVER	PER-001
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	no
NEVER DELEGATED	yes
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	The expert's own statement of it, or a source that has been checked.
ESCALATION	Where neither exists the fact is not written at all; it becomes an open question with a decider and a date.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a figure or citation the expert did not supply and that has not been verified, when a section is drafted, then it does not appear in the document. • Given a citation that was checked and could not be confirmed, when it is reported, then it is marked unverified rather than stated as fact.

TR-006 · Judge whether a PRD can be built from

APPROVER	PER-002
AN AGENT MAY DECIDE	yes
NEVER DELEGATED	no
EVIDENCE REQUIRED	The release line, the requirements covering each stage, and a quotation for every gap claimed.
ESCALATION	The engineering lead's own judgement overrides any reported verdict; the report is evidence for them, not a substitute for them.
ACCEPTANCE	• Given a reported verdict, when the engineering lead disagrees, then their judgement is recorded as the verdict and the report is kept alongside it. • Given a reported gap, when it is stated, then the document is quoted for it.

SECTION 11

Assumptions, risks and dependencies

DRAFT

Assumptions

ID	ASSUMPTION	IF FALSE
A-001	An expert will answer 50-100 questions across a few sittings	The method fails; sections 5-7 change completely
A-002	An expert will act on a grade they did not produce	The grading is decoration
A-003	An engineering lead accepts a PRD naming no technology	Test 5 becomes a liability
A-004	Organisations permit drafting inside an assistant session	C-001 and C-003 have to change

A-001 and A-002 are the two the product stands on, and neither has been tested. Both are validated by the same ten observed sessions (D-002), which makes D-002 the single most load-bearing dependency in this PRD.

Risks

ID	RISK	L	I	OWNER
R-001	High score becomes false assurance	high	high	Richard Hightower
R-002	Unsupported findings destroy trust in all findings	high	high	Richard Hightower
R-003	A beautifully graded PRD for the wrong product	medium	high	Richard Hightower
R-004	Interview too long; sets abandoned	medium	medium	Richard Hightower
R-005	A version change strands an expert's set	low	high	Richard Hightower

R-003 is not closed. The mitigations listed reduce it and do not solve it. Nothing in this product checks whether the product being specified should exist. That is stated here rather than hidden behind a mitigation that sounds adequate.

Dependencies

ID	NEED	FROM	BY	STATUS
D-001	An assistant session able to carry the interview	The customer's platform	2027-01-31	committed
D-002	10 observed first-time experts	Early customers	2027-03-31	requested
D-003	3 engineering leads to read a set cold	Early customers	2027-03-31	requested

D-002 and D-003 are both merely requested, and both are dated after R1's target in section 13. That is a real schedule problem: R1 ships before the assumptions it rests on are tested. Recorded, not resolved.

Assumptions

A-001

ASSUMPTION	A domain expert will answer fifty to a hundred questions about their own field across a few sittings, if each one is clearly worth answering.
IF FALSE	The whole method fails. The product would have to produce a usable partial PRD from perhaps fifteen answers, which changes sections 5, 6 and 7 completely and makes the grading thresholds meaningless.
VALIDATED BY	Observed sessions with 10 first-time experts, counting where they stop - the same sessions NFR-005 uses.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

A-002 · An expert will act on a grade they did not produce, rather than dismissing it.

IF FALSE	The grading is decoration and sections 3 and 7 are measuring something nobody uses. The product reduces to a structured interview.
VALIDATED BY	In the same observed sessions, whether the expert answers the one question or moves on regardless.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

A-003

ASSUMPTION	An engineering lead will accept a PRD that names no technology, rather than reading the absence as incompleteness.
IF FALSE	Test 5 becomes a liability rather than a discipline, and the candidate architecture decisions list in FR-007 has to become a first-class output rather than a hand-over note.
VALIDATED BY	Three engineering leads reading a completed set cold and saying what they would ask for first.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

A-004

ASSUMPTION	Organisations will let a specification for their product be drafted inside an assistant session.
IF FALSE	C-001 and C-003 are unacceptable as written and the delivery model has to change, which invalidates most of section 7's assumptions about immediacy.
VALIDATED BY	The information security review of the first three customer engagements.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

Risks

R-001

RISK	The expert accepts a weak PRD because the score was high. The grade becomes false assurance, which is worse than no grade.
LIKELIHOOD	high
IMPACT	high
MITIGATION	Blocking defects are counted and reported separately from the score and no score clears them (FR-009); the non-goal in section 6 says explicitly that a grade is evidence, not a warrant; FR-012 puts a buildability verdict in front of the expert before approval.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

R-002

RISK	The grading reports findings that are not in the document. The expert catches one, stops trusting all of them, and the grading becomes noise they skip.
LIKELIHOOD	high
IMPACT	high
MITIGATION	Every finding must quote the document, and anything unsupported is dropped before the expert sees it (FR-009, TR-003, TR-006); a refuted finding is acknowledged as dropped rather than defended (SC-004).
OWNER	Richard Hightower

R-003

RISK	A fluent, well-structured, well-graded PRD is produced for the wrong product, and the structure makes the error harder to see rather than easier.
LIKELIHOOD	medium
IMPACT	high
MITIGATION	Section 3 asks what would move the objectives without this product at all; section 1 requires evidence per problem and names what is unmeasured. Neither is sufficient - this risk is not closed, and a reviewer should say so.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

R-004

RISK	The interview is too long to finish, so sets are abandoned half-written and the product is remembered as the thing that asked a hundred questions.
LIKELIHOOD	medium
IMPACT	medium
MITIGATION	FR-005 lets the expert end any section and records what was left; FR-002 makes resumption cheap; the working order in the method puts the sections that unlock the others first, so an abandoned set is still useful.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

R-005

RISK	A set written by one version cannot be read or graded by a later one, and an expert loses weeks of thinking to an upgrade.
LIKELIHOOD	low
IMPACT	high
MITIGATION	NFR-004 makes every set readable with no part of the product running; NFR-009 requires older sets to stay gradable within a major version.
OWNER	Richard Hightower

Dependencies

D-001

NEED	An assistant session the expert is already working in, able to carry a long interview and read and write the documents.
FROM	The assistant platform the customer already uses
BY	2027-01-31
STATUS	committed
BLOCKS	• ST-001 • ST-002

D-002 · Ten first-time domain experts willing to be observed completing a PRD.

FROM	Early customers and the professional network
BY	2027-03-31
STATUS	requested
BLOCKS	• A-001 • A-002 • NFR-005

D-003

NEED	Three engineering leads willing to read a completed set cold and report what they would ask for first.
FROM	Early customers
BY	2027-03-31
STATUS	requested
BLOCKS	• A-003 • O-001

SECTION 12

Open questions

DRAFT

ID	QUESTION	DECIDER	BY	BLOCKS
Q-001	Today's first-pass buildability rate	R. Hightower	2027-03-31	O-001
Q-002	Today's idea-to-approval elapsed time	R. Hightower	2027-03-31	O-002
Q-003	Today's share of testable requirements	R. Hightower	2027-03-31	O-003
Q-004	Segment sizes, and which converts	R. Hightower	2027-06-30	S-001..S-003
Q-005	Will a sponsor accept a graded specification	R. Hightower + 3 sponsors	2027-05-31	FR-013, TR-001
Q-006	Sections completed per sitting, and where they stop	R. Hightower	2027-03-31	R-004, NFR-005
Q-007	Is the working order right, and how does looping back feel	R. Hightower	2027-03-31	ST-004
Q-008	Disciplined or incomplete, to an engineering lead	R. Hightower + 3 leads	2027-03-31	A-003

The three that matter most

Q-001 to Q-003 are the baselines for all three objectives. Until they are answered, section 3's targets are intentions. Nothing should be committed to a plan on the strength of them.

Q-005 is the one that could invalidate the product's central idea. If showing a sponsor a grade reduces their confidence rather than raising it, then FR-013 is wrong and the grading becomes an author's private tool rather than part of the approval. That is a cheap two-day question and it should be asked early.

Q-008 tests test 5. If engineering leads read the absence of technology as incompleteness, the discipline this whole product enforces is a liability, and A-003 fails.

Honest note

Every decider here is the same person. For a one-person product that is accurate; for anything larger it is a defect, and the first thing to fix when there is a second person.

Q-001

QUESTION: What share of specifications reaching a development team today pass a buildability review on first submission?

DECIDER: Richard Hightower

BY: 2027-03-31

BLOCKS:
- O-001

SPIKE: Run the eleven derivability checks against ten specifications collected from real engagements, and count. Time-boxed to 3 days.

Q-002

QUESTION: How long does it take today, in working days, from a product idea to an approved specification?

DECIDER: Richard Hightower

BY: 2027-03-31

BLOCKS:
- O-002

SPIKE: Reconstruct the timeline from first discussion to approval for five recent engagements. Time-boxed to 2 days.

Q-003

QUESTION: What share of functional requirements in today's specifications can an engineer who was not in the interview write a test from?

DECIDER: Richard Hightower

BY: 2027-03-31

BLOCKS:
- O-003

SPIKE: Three engineering leads score the requirements of the same ten specifications from Q-001, independently. Time-boxed to 3 days.

Q-004

QUESTION: How many organisations are in each segment in section 2, and which segment actually converts?

DECIDER: Richard Hightower

BY: 2027-06-30

BLOCKS:
- S-001
- S-002
- S-003

SPIKE: Name the register or source per segment and count; then compare against the first ten conversations. Time-boxed to 5 days.

Q-005

QUESTION: Will a sponsor accept a specification that carries a machine-produced grade, or does the grade reduce their confidence rather than raise it?

DECIDER: Richard Hightower, with the first three sponsors

BY: 2027-05-31

BLOCKS:
- FR-013
- TR-001

SPIKE: Show three sponsors the same set with and without grades and ask which they would approve. Time-boxed to 2 days.

Q-006

QUESTION	How many sections will an expert complete in one sitting before stopping, and which section do they stop at?
DECIDER	Richard Hightower
BY	2027-03-31
BLOCKS	• R-004 • NFR-005
SPIKE	Count in the ten observed sessions from D-002. No extra work.

Q-007

QUESTION	Is the working order in the method right - does writing the requirements really send an expert back to the journeys, and does that feel like progress or like failure to them?
DECIDER	Richard Hightower
BY	2027-03-31
BLOCKS	• ST-004
SPIKE	Count loop-backs and ask the expert how it felt, in the ten observed sessions. No extra work.

Q-008

QUESTION	Does an engineering lead read a PRD that names no technology as disciplined or as incomplete?
DECIDER	Richard Hightower, with the three leads from D-003
BY	2027-03-31
BLOCKS	• A-003
SPIKE	Ask each lead, after reading a set cold, whether anything was missing and whether they wanted a technology named. Time-boxed to 1 day.

SECTION 13

Release plan

DRAFT

ID	RELEASE	STAGES	TARGET
REL-001	Single-expert PRD authoring	ST-001..ST-006	2027-03-31
REL-002	Backlog derivation	ST-007, ST-008	2027-06-30
REL-003	More than one author	—	none

Why this order

REL-001 is exactly the release line in section 6. It is the smallest release in which anyone gets anything: an expert reaching an approved, reviewed PRD.

REL-002 is deferred rather than cut because the PRD REL-001 produces already has to carry everything a backlog needs — FR-012 checks precisely that. Deferring the derivation costs nothing; deferring what it needs would have cost a rewrite.

REL-003 waits for evidence that one author's path works at all. Building for two authors before one is proven would be building on A-001 and A-002 before either is tested.

The schedule problem, stated plainly

REL-001 targets 2027-03-31. D-002 and D-003 in section 11 — the ten observed experts and the three engineering leads — are also dated 2027-03-31 and are only *requested*. So REL-001 ships at the same moment the assumptions beneath it are first tested, not after. Either REL-001 moves, or it ships knowingly as an experiment. That is a decision for the sponsor at TR-001 and it is not made here.

Not in this section, deliberately

No tasks, no estimates, no sizing, no team assignments, and no technology milestone. Those come from engineering design and iteration planning.

REL-001 · Single-expert PRD authoring

OUTCOMES

- A domain expert with no product training can take one product idea to an approved PRD without leaving the session they started in.
- The expert can see, before anyone estimates, which parts of their own specification a development team could not build from.
- A sponsor can see what they are approving, what is still open and who owns each open thing, on one page.

JOURNEY STAGES

- ST-001
- ST-002
- ST-003
- ST-004
- ST-005
- ST-006

REQUIREMENTS

- FR-001
- FR-002
- FR-003
- FR-004
- FR-005
- FR-006
- FR-007
- FR-008
- FR-009
- FR-010
- FR-011
- FR-012
- FR-013
- FR-014

OBJECTIVES

- O-001
- O-002
- O-003

TARGET DATE

2027-03-31

REL-002 · Backlog derivation

OUTCOMES

- A delivery lead can walk into a story-mapping workshop with features and a release line already derived from the approved PRD.
- Every story names the requirement id it came from, so nobody has to ask why it exists.

JOURNEY STAGES

- ST-007
- ST-008

OBJECTIVES

- O-001

TARGET DATE

2027-06-30

REL-003 · More than one author

OUTCOMES

- Two experts can work on different sections of the same specification without overwriting each other.
- A reviewer can comment on a section without being able to change it.

OBJECTIVES

- O-002

SECTION 14

Glossary

DRAFT

TERM	MOST OFTEN CONFUSED WITH
PRD	A design document
Golden thread	The most important journey
Release line	A date
Stage	A screen
Rubric	A checklist
Blocking defect	A low score
Score	A verdict on the product idea
Spike	A piece of the product
Open question	A risk
Non-goal	Out of scope

The `not` column above is the one that earns its keep. Every one of these has been confused in practice, and three of them — golden thread, blocking defect and score — carry a cost when confused: a team picks the wrong journey for release 1, ships a section with a known fault because the number looked good, or believes a well-written specification means a sound product.

PRD

MEANING

A written statement of what to build, for whom, why, and how you know it works, plus what not to build. It does not say how to build it.

SEE ALSO

- section
- document set

NOT

A design document. A PRD that names components or technologies has stopped being a PRD and has started being an architecture sketch.

Document set

MEANING

One directory of documents that together are one PRD: an index and one document per section, each linking to the others.

SEE ALSO

- PRD

Golden thread

MEANING

The one user journey that release 1 must deliver from end to end.

SEE ALSO

- journey
- release line

NOT

The most important journey in general. It is the journey chosen for release 1, which is often the simplest rather than the most valuable.

Release line

MEANING

The smallest set of journey stages that completes the golden thread, and so the boundary of what release 1 contains.

SEE ALSO

- golden thread
- scope

NOT

A date or a deadline. It is a line across the journey, not across a calendar.

Stage

MEANING

One large step of a journey, naming a person, an input, an output and a decision.

SEE ALSO

- journey
- step

NOT

A screen or a system step. A stage survives a redesign.

The five tests

MEANING

The five properties a statement must have to be a product requirement: it names a user, states an outcome a person can see, has a pass-or-fail acceptance test, carries a priority, and does not name the component or technology that delivers it.

SEE ALSO

- blocking defect

Rubric

MEANING

The stated standard a section is scored against: a set of dimensions, each with written anchors for what a score of 0, 2 and 4 look like.

SEE ALSO

- score
- blocking defect

NOT

A checklist. A checklist asks whether something is present; a rubric asks how good it is, against written anchors.

Blocking defect

MEANING

A named fault that stops a section advancing however high its score is, such as a requirement that names a technology or an id that refers to nothing.

SEE ALSO

- rubric
- score

NOT

A low score. Score and blocking defects are counted separately and a high score never clears a blocking defect.

Score

MEANING

A section's total against its rubric, 0 to 100, written by a grading pass and never by hand.

SEE ALSO

- rubric
- blocking defect

NOT

A measure of whether the product is a good idea. It measures how well the section is written, nothing else.

Spike

MEANING

A time-boxed piece of work whose only output is an answer to an open question, or a recorded decision.

SEE ALSO

- open question

NOT

A piece of the product. A spike produces knowledge, not a feature.

Open question

MEANING

Something not yet decided, recorded with the one person who decides it and the date by which they must.

SEE ALSO

- spike
- assumption

NOT

A risk. A risk is something that might happen and nobody can simply decide; an open question has a decider.

Non-goal

MEANING

Something a reasonable reader would expect the product to do, that it will not do, with no plan to.

SEE ALSO

- scope

NOT

Out of scope. Out of scope means not yet, with a condition for revisiting; a non-goal means not ever, with a reason.

SECTION 15

Change log and approvals

DRAFT

VERSION	DATE	AUTHOR	WHAT CHANGED
0.1.0	2026-10-23	Richard Hightower	First draft of all sixteen sections

0.1.0 — what to know

Written as prd-forge's own first exercise. Three things a reader should carry forward:

1. **No baselines.** All three objectives carry an explicit unknown with a matching open question (Q-001 to Q-003). The targets are intentions, not commitments.
2. **C-001 is the tension.** The product is delivered inside an assistant session. Naming that in a requirement would fail test 5, so it is recorded as a constraint. A reviewer may fairly call it architecture.
3. **R-003 is not closed.** Nothing in this product checks whether the product being specified should exist at all.

Approvals

None sought. This set is at `draft` and has not been offered for approval. It cannot reach `final` without an approval recorded here, per TR-001.

> **First draft of the whole set, written with prd-forge's own conventions as the product's fi**
>
> VERSION 0.1.0
>
> DATE 2026-10-23
>
> AUTHOR Richard Hightower
>
> SECTIONS
> - 1
> - 2
> - 3
> - 4
> - 5
> - 6
> - 7
> - 8
> - 9
> - 10
> - 11
> - 12
> - 13
> - 14
> - 15